

Lesson 09:

Structural Coherence of a Passage:

Al-Baqarah and An-Naba

Lesson 09: Structural Coherence of Passage: Al-Baqarah and An-Naba

The symmetrical structure of Surah Al-Baqarah (122-133) teaches us a profound lesson about the importance of remembering Allah's favors, while the pairing in Surah An-Naba prompts those who reflect to arrive to a powerful conclusion about the afterlife.

Case Study #1: Surah Al-Baqarah (122-133)

Section	Ayah
A	يَا بَنِي إِسْرَائِيلَ اذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتِيَ الَّتِي أَنْعَمْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ وَأَلِيّ فَصَلُّوهُمْ عَلَى الْعَالَمِينَ ﴿١٢٢﴾ وَاتَّقُوا يَوْمًا لَا تَجْزِي نَفْسٌ عَنْ نَفْسٍ شَيْئًا وَلَا يُقْبَلُ مِنْهَا عَدْلٌ وَلَا تَنْفَعُهَا شَفَاعَةٌ وَلَا هُمْ يُنصَرُونَ ﴿١٢٣﴾
B	وَإِذِ ابْتَلَىٰ إِبْرَاهِيمَ رَبُّهُ بِكَلِمَاتٍ فَأَتَمَّهُنَّ ۖ قَالَ إِنِّي جَاعِلُكَ لِلنَّاسِ إِمَامًا ۖ قَالَ وَمِنْ ذُرِّيَّتِي ۖ قَالَ لَا يَنَالُ عَهْدِي الظَّالِمِينَ ﴿١٢٤﴾
C	وَإِذْ جَعَلْنَا الْبَيْتَ مَثَابَةً لِّلنَّاسِ وَأَمْنًا وَاتَّخِذُوا مِن مَّقَامِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ مُصَلًّى ۖ وَعَهِدْنَا إِلَىٰ إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَإِسْمَاعِيلَ أَنَّ طَهِّرَا بَيْتِيَ لِلطَّائِفِينَ وَالْقَائِمِينَ وَالرُّكَّعِ السُّجُودِ ﴿١٢٥﴾
D	وَإِذْ قَالَ إِبْرَاهِيمُ رَبِّ اجْعَلْ هَذَا بَلَدًا آمِنًا وَارْزُقْ أَهْلَهُ مِنَ الثَّمَرَاتِ مَنْ آمَنَ مِنْهُمْ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ ۖ قَالَ وَمَنْ كَفَرَ فَأُمَتِّعُهُ قَلِيلًا ثُمَّ أَضْطَرُّهُ إِلَىٰ عَذَابِ النَّارِ ۖ وَبِئْسَ الْمَصِيرُ ﴿١٢٦﴾
C	وَإِذْ يَرْفَعُ إِبْرَاهِيمُ الْقَوَاعِدَ مِنَ الْبَيْتِ وَإِسْمَاعِيلُ رَبَّنَا تَقَبَّلْ مِنَّا ۖ إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ السَّمِيعُ الْعَلِيمُ ﴿١٢٧﴾
B	رَبَّنَا وَاجْعَلْنَا مُسْلِمَيْنِ لَكَ وَمِنْ ذُرِّيَّتِنَا أُمَّةً مُّسْلِمَةً لَّكَ وَأَرِنَا مَنَاسِكَنَا وَتُبْ عَلَيْنَا ۖ إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ التَّوَّابُ الرَّحِيمُ ﴿١٢٨﴾ رَبَّنَا وَابْعَثْ فِيهِمْ رَسُولًا مِنْهُمْ يَتْلُو عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتِكَ وَيُعَلِّمُهُمُ الْكِتَابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَيُزَكِّيهِمْ ۖ إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ ﴿١٢٩﴾
A	وَمَنْ يَرْغَبْ عَن مِّلَّةِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِلَّا مَن سَفِهَ نَفْسَهُ ۚ وَلَقَدِ اصْطَفَيْنَاهُ فِي الدُّنْيَا ۖ وَإِنَّهُ فِي الْآخِرَةِ لَمِنَ الصَّالِحِينَ ﴿١٣٠﴾ إِذْ قَالَ لَهُ رَبُّهُ أَسْلِمْ ۖ قَالَ أَسْلَمْتُ لِرَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ ﴿١٣١﴾ وَوَصَّىٰ بِهَا إِبْرَاهِيمُ بَنِيهِ وَيَعْقُوبُ يَا بَنِيَّ إِنَّ اللَّهَ اصْطَفَىٰ لَكُمُ الدِّينَ فَلَا تَمُوتُنَّ إِلَّا وَأَنتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ ﴿١٣٢﴾ أَمْ كُنْتُمْ شُهَدَاءَ إِذْ حَضَرَ يَعْقُوبَ الْمَوْتُ إِذْ قَالَ لِبَنِيهِ مَا تَعْبُدُونَ مِن بَعْدِي قَالُوا نَعْبُدُ إِلَهَكَ وَإِلَهَ آبَائِكَ إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَإِسْمَاعِيلَ وَإِسْحَاقَ إِلَٰهًا وَاحِدًا وَنَحْنُ لَهُ مُسْلِمُونَ ﴿١٣٣﴾

Section	Translation
A	O Children of Israel, make mention of My favor which I have bestowed upon you and that I gave you preference over all nations. (122) And be mindful of a Day in which no soul will be compensated for another, nor will an equivalent be taken from it, nor will any intercession benefit it, nor will they be aided. (123)
B	And [remember] when his Master thoroughly tested Ibrahim with [certain] commands and he fulfilled them. [Allah] said, "No doubt, I will make you a leader over the people." [Ibrahim] said, "And [what] of my offsprings?" [Allah] said, "My guarantee does not extend to the wrongdoers." (124)
C	And [remember] when We made the House a place of return for the people and [a place of] peace/security. And take, [O believers], by the station of Ibrahim, a place of prayer. And We have taken a covenant from Ibrahim and Ismail, [saying], "Purify My House for those who perform Tawaf and those who are staying [there] for worship and those who bow and prostrate [in prayer]." (125)
D	And [remember] when Ibrahim said, "My Master, make this a peaceful/secure city and provide its people with fruits - whoever of them who believes in Allah and the Last Day." [Allah] said. "And whoever disbelieves - I will grant him enjoyment for a little; then I will force him to the punishment of the Fire, and wretched is the destination [i.e. What a terrible place to be that is!]." (126)
C	And [remember] when Ibrahim was raising the foundations of the House [along with] Ismail, [saying], "Our Master, accept [this] from both of us. Certainly, You are the All-Hearing, All-Knowing. (127)
B	Our Master, and make both of us Muslims [i.e. submissive] before You and from our offspring a Muslim nation [i.e. a submissive nation] to You. And show us our rituals and accept our repentance. Certainly, You are the One who Continually and Repeatedly Accepts Repentance, Always Loving and Caring. (128) Our Master, and appoint from among them a messenger [who comes] from [among] themselves who will recite to Your miraculous signs unto them and teach them the Book and the Wisdom and purify them. Certainly, You are the Ultimate Authority, Ultimately Wise." (129)

A	And who would turn away from the religion of Ibrahim except one who makes a fool of himself. And We had chosen him in this world, and certainly he, in the Hereafter, will be among the righteous. (130) When his Master said to him, "Submit", he said "I have submitted [myself] before the Master of all people." (131) And Ibrahim counselled his children [to do the same] and [so did] Yaaqub, [saying], "O my children, no doubt Allah has chosen for you this religion, so do not dare die except in a state of you being Muslims." (132) Or were you witnesses when death approached Yaaqub, when he said to his sons, "What will you worship after me?" They said, "We will worship your God and the God of your fathers, Ibrahim and Ismail and Ishaq - one God. And we are Muslims [in submission] before Him." (133)
---	--

Connection

Associations are drawn between ayat with similar subject matter. (*Note: "Top" refers to the top ayah/ayat in the symmetry, while "Bottom" refers to the bottom ayah/ayat in the symmetry.*)

Section A (122-123, 130-32)

- *Top*: The Israelites were told to be grateful and to mention Allah's favor upon them, that they have been given preference over all other nations.
- *Bottom*: The favor of Islam, that is passed down from Ibrahim (PBUH) to Ishaq (PBUH) to Yaqub/Israel (PBUH) to them (i.e. Bani Israel), is mentioned.

Section B (124, 128-129)

- *Top*: Ibrahim (PBUH) was made a leader over the people. He asked, "What about my kids?" Allah responded, "My promise does not extend to wrongdoers."
- *Bottom*: The two corresponding prayers of Ibrahim are mentioned: (1) let one ummah among my children be Muslim and (2) appoint to them a prophet.

Section C (125, 127)

- *Top*: The purpose of the House (as a place that people can return to; a place of peace and security; of prayer) and its building by Ibrahim (PBUH) and Ismail (PBUH) are mentioned.
- *Bottom*: The corresponding prayer of Ibrahim (PBUH) and Ismail (PBUH), as they are building the House, that their effort is accepted, is mentioned.

Section D (126)

- *Center of section*: The prayer of Ibrahim (PBUH) for the safety & provision of the city. Allah said, "Believe! If not, there is punishment."
- The heart of this passage is the secret which the Israelites were unable to live by.

- The conversation began with the Israelites who have always wanted safety and considered themselves especially provided for. They claimed God has especially promised them (hence the term, Promised Land – the promise that was given to Ibrahim (PBUH)).
- However this passage argues that the actual narrative of Ibrahim (PBUH) is this one. The reason they were suffering a tough history – being exiled, humiliated and degraded – was because they were not making mention of the favor of Allah upon them i.e. Islam itself. If they did, they would have the promise of Ibrahim (PBUH) fulfilled upon them – but “My guarantee does not extend to the wrongdoers” (124).

Symmetry/Ring composition within passages

Case Study #2: Surah An-Naba (6-13)

Section	Ayah
A	أَلَمْ نَجْعَلِ الْأَرْضَ مِهَادًا ﴿٦﴾ وَالْجِبَالَ أَوْتَادًا ﴿٧﴾
B	وَخَلَقْنَاكُمْ أَزْوَاجًا ﴿٨﴾
C	وَجَعَلْنَا نَوْمَكُمْ سُبَاتًا ﴿٩﴾
B	وَجَعَلْنَا اللَّيْلَ لِبَاسًا ﴿١٠﴾ وَجَعَلْنَا النَّهَارَ مَعَاشًا ﴿١١﴾
A	وَبَنَيْنَا فَوْقَكُمْ سَبْعًا شِدَادًا ﴿١٢﴾ وَجَعَلْنَا سِرَاجًا وَهَّاجًا ﴿١٣﴾

Section	Translation
A	Did We not make the earth into a cradle? (6) And the mountains into pegs? (7)
B	And We created you into pairs (8)
C	And We made your sleep into [something that is] cut-off (9)
B	And We made the night into a garment (10) And We made the day into a means of living (11)
A	And We constructed above you seven intense [heavens] (12) And We made [therein] a burning lamp (13)

Connection

Section A

- *Top*: Vast view – the earth. The thing most prominent that sticks out in that view – the mountains.
- *Bottom*: Vast view – the skies. The thing most prominent that sticks out in that view – the sun.

Section B

- *Top*: Allah makes us into pairs of males and females.
- *Bottom*: Allah makes night and day into pairs.
- In al-Lail, Allah also makes a comparison between night and day with females and males: ﴿۱﴾ وَاللَّيْلِ إِذَا يَغْشَىٰ ﴿۲﴾ وَالنَّهَارِ إِذَا تَجَلَّىٰ ﴿۳﴾ وَمَا خَلَقَ الذَّكَرَ وَالْأُنثَىٰ (92:1-3) – *By the night when it covers (1) And [by] the day when it appears (2) And [by] He who created the male and female (3)*
- Parallels between Night and Day vs. Women and Men:
 - They complement each other – the exhaustion of the day finds comfort in the night, similar to husbands find comfort in their wives.
 - Men and women seek a living during the day (مَعَاشًا), and become garments (لِبَاسًا) for another at night
 - Lesson: Just the way night and day balance each other, a husband and wife need to find balance between enjoyment and responsibilities. Without either, the marriage institution may collapse.

Section C

- *Center*: Sleep – the only subject being excluded from its pair!
 - This is the heart of the passage. If everything else is paired, then sleep should be paired with *waking up*. Incredibly, the central theme of An-Naba is about the Day of Judgment where humanity will...wake up!
 - This pairing is not mentioned explicitly to suggest that just as we may find it obvious that after sleep comes waking up, it should also be obvious that after death (i.e. 'sleep' in the grave) comes resurrection (i.e. 'waking up')!